What to letter, what to film

Two lists. The lettering is the long one — do it in whatever order suits you, but the first tier is where all the value is.

> **Before you start:** If you letter in capitals — and most block lettering is — then do all 26 capitals at twenty each and skip the lowercase tiers entirely. That is a third of the work for the same result.

LIST ONE · THE LETTERING

As many as you can stand – aim for twenty each

These carry the whole thing. Twenty versions means a letter can appear twenty times before it repeats itself — which is the difference between handwriting and a font.

DIGITS

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

Highest priority of the lot. A recipe is full of 350°F, 100%, 2:00, 1100 — repeated digits sitting side by side, where a repeat shows most.

THE COMMON LOWERCASE

e t a o i n s r h l d c u m

THE COMMON UPPERCASE

A C D E F G H I M N O P R S T W

A sheet's worth – about eight each

Common enough to repeat in a sentence, rare enough that eight covers it.

THE REST OF THE LOWERCASE

b f g j k p q v w x y z

THE REST OF THE UPPERCASE

B J K L Q U V X Y Z

EVERYDAY PUNCTUATION

. , ' " ! ? : ; -

TICK AND CROSS

✓ ✗

Drawn as letters so they sit on the line with the text. Used constantly in the this-works / this-doesn't comparisons.

Just a couple – three each is plenty

Rare enough that three will never show a repeat. Don't labour these.

BRACKETS AND DASHES

( ) [ ] / – — … & % + = < > * # @ $

The – is an en dash for ranges (75–80°F). The — is an em dash. Both differ from the hyphen.

MEASUREMENT

° ℃ ℉ ± × ÷ ~ ≈ ≤ ≥ ′ ″ −

× is a multiplication sign, not the letter x — 2 × 4 should never be lettered with an x. The − is a true minus, drawn longer than a hyphen: in −20°C a hyphen reads as a typo.

FRACTIONS

½ ⅓ ⅔ ¼ ¾ ⅛ ⅜ ⅝ ⅞

Baking runs on these.

CHEMISTRY

$_{0\ 1\ 2\ 3\ 4\ 5\ 6\ 7\ 8\ 9}$ $^{0\ 1\ 2\ 3\ 4\ 5\ 6\ 7\ 8\ 9\ +\ -}$

Subscripts and superscripts. Without them every formula — $C_6H_{12}O_6$, CO_2 — falls back to another font mid-word, and it is instantly visible.

ARROWS

→ ← ↔ ⇌ ↑ ↓ ⟶

⇌ is the important one. Fermentation and enzyme reactions are equilibria; a one-way → where a ⇌ belongs is a factual error, not a typographic one.

GREEK

α β Δ μ λ π

α and β for glucose anomers, Δ for change, μ for micro.

ACCENTS

é è ê à â ç ñ ü ö

sauté, purée, pâte, crème, jalapeño.

HOWEVER YOU DO IT

- **One marker, one sitting, per character.** Twenty e's drawn across three days in three moods read as three different fonts. Twenty drawn in a row read as one hand.
- **Leave the mess in.** The bleed, the skips where the marker lifted, the wobble — those are the parts that make it yours. Tidying them defeats the whole exercise.
- **Scan at 1200 dpi, untouched.** No threshold, no cleanup, no sharpening. Send the file exactly as the scanner made it.

LIST TWO · THE FILMING

Three recordings. None of this has been tested against real footage yet — only against audio I synthesised, which by definition matches my own assumptions and finds nothing.

Two minutes of you talking

2 minutes

Nothing in this pipeline has ever met real speech. It has been tested entirely against synthetic audio I wrote to match my own assumptions, which finds nothing.

1. Shoot it at 24p. Not 30 — the whole timeline runs at 24 and 30 would make every graphic land at the wrong moment.
2. Real location, real microphone, the way you'd actually shoot.
3. Talk about anything. Yeast, the weather, what you had for lunch.
4. Leave your natural pauses in. Don't perform tightly.
5. Fluff two or three lines on purpose — start a sentence, stop, and say it again. That's the thing I most need to see it handle.
6. Don't edit it. Send the original file.

One minute of room tone

60 seconds

Silence under every cut. Digital silence between sentences is the loudest tell that a machine made the edit, so real room tone runs underneath.

1. Same room, same mic, same settings, immediately after the talking.
2. Nobody speaks. Don't move. Just let it run.
3. Once per location — if you shoot in the kitchen and at the table, that's two.

The grey card, on each camera

10 minutes

The T3i is a 2011 body and is visibly greener and flatter than the R100 and RP. One correction across all three would make cuts between cameras read as a mistake.

1. Same scene, same light, same white balance — only the camera changes.
2. Grey card and colour checker filling a good part of the frame.
3. A few seconds on each of the three bodies: T3i, R100, RP.
4. Label which is which, or shoot them in that order and tell me.

Send everything however's easiest. Originals, not screenshots, and nothing that re-compresses on the way.